

# **LATE DIAGNOSED**

A Self-Discovery Workbook  
for Autistic Adults

You're not broken. You're autistic.  
And that's a beautiful thing to discover.

**Daniel Tesfamariam**

# **LATE DIAGNOSED**

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# WELCOME TO YOUR NEUROTYPED

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If you were diagnosed as an adult (or suspect you're autistic), you may be feeling a mix of:

- Relief ('So THAT'S why!')
- Grief (for years of struggling without support)
- Anger (at being missed/dismissed)
- Confusion (what does this mean for me?)
- Imposter syndrome ('Am I autistic enough?')
- Excitement (finally understanding yourself)

**ALL of these are valid. This workbook is YOUR space to explore.**

## UNDERSTANDING YOUR AUTISTIC IDENTITY

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**What autism means to ME (not textbook definitions):**

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**Moments in my past that NOW make sense:**

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**My autistic strengths:**

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## WHO AM I WITHOUT THE MASK?

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**What I do to appear 'normal':**

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**What I'd do if no one was watching:**

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**Social rules I follow that exhaust me:**

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**My natural way of communicating:**

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## MASKS I WEAR

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**At work I pretend to:**

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**With family I hide:**

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**With friends I force myself to:**

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**The cost of masking (what it takes from me):**

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## UNMASKING SAFELY

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Safe people I can be unmasked with:

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Environments where I don't mask:

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One mask I want to slowly drop:

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What I need to feel safe being myself:

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# SENSORY PROFILE BUILDER

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## **SOUND:**

Overwhelms: \_\_\_\_\_

Soothes: \_\_\_\_\_

## **SIGHT:**

Overwhelms: \_\_\_\_\_

Soothes: \_\_\_\_\_

## **TOUCH:**

Overwhelms: \_\_\_\_\_

Soothes: \_\_\_\_\_

## **SMELL:**

Overwhelms: \_\_\_\_\_

Soothes: \_\_\_\_\_

## **TASTE:**

Overwhelms: \_\_\_\_\_

Soothes: \_\_\_\_\_

## **MOVEMENT:**

Overwhelms: \_\_\_\_\_

Soothes: \_\_\_\_\_



# COMMUNICATION PREFERENCES

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**I communicate best when:**

- ☐ Writing vs ☐ Speaking
- ☐ One-on-one vs ☐ Groups
- ☐ Direct/blunt vs ☐ Softened language
- ☐ Time to process vs ☐ On the spot
- ☐ Structured topics vs ☐ Open-ended chat

**Things I wish people knew about how I communicate:**

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# SOCIAL BATTERY MANAGEMENT

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**My social battery:**

Full charge lasts approximately: \_\_\_\_ hours of socializing

Recharge time needed: \_\_\_\_ hours alone

**What DRAINS my battery fastest:**

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**What RECHARGES me:**

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**Signs my battery is low:**

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## SPECIAL INTERESTS AS SELF-CARE

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**Your special interests are not 'obsessions.' They are JOY.**

My current special interests:

1. \_\_\_\_\_
2. \_\_\_\_\_
3. \_\_\_\_\_

Past special interests I look back on fondly:

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**How I can protect time for my interests:**

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**Ways my interests HELP me (regulation, joy, purpose):**

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# EXECUTIVE FUNCTION STRATEGIES

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**Task initiation:**

Body doubling, timers, 'just do 2 min', pair with special interest

**Transitions:**

Warnings (timer 10 min before), routines, transition objects

**Planning:**

Visual schedules, one task at a time, external reminders

**Time awareness:**

Analog clocks, time-timer app, alarms for everything

**Organization:**

Everything has a visible home, labels, clear containers

**Emotional regulation:**

Stim freely, sensory tools, alone time, scripting

# AUTISTIC BURNOUT RECOGNITION

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Autistic burnout is different from regular burnout:

- Loss of skills you used to have (speech, driving, self-care)
- Extreme exhaustion that sleep doesn't fix
- Increased sensory sensitivity
- Loss of ability to mask
- Increased meltdowns/shutdowns
- Memory problems
- Physical illness
- Can't do 'simple' things

## **Prevention plan:**

Daily rest needed: \_\_\_\_ Weekly alone time: \_\_\_\_

Masking I can reduce: \_\_\_\_\_

Demands I can delegate/drop: \_\_\_\_\_

# ACCOMMODATIONS I DESERVE

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## AT WORK:

- ☐ Noise-canceling headphones
- ☐ Written instructions
- ☐ Flexible schedule
- ☐ Reduced meetings
- ☐ Clear expectations

## AT HOME:

- ☐ Sensory-friendly spaces
- ☐ Predictable routines
- ☐ Time alone
- ☐ Reduced household demands
- ☐ Safe foods always available

## SOCIALLY:

- ☐ Permission to leave early
- ☐ Advance notice of plans
- ☐ One-on-one instead of groups
- ☐ Text instead of call
- ☐ No surprise visitors

# RELATIONSHIP NAVIGATION

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**What I need in relationships (any kind):**

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**What I struggle with in relationships:**

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**How to tell people about my autism:**

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**Scripts:**

'I'm autistic, which means I \_\_\_\_\_,'

'It helps me when you \_\_\_\_\_,'

'I need \_\_\_\_\_ to be at my best'

## GRIEF FOR THE YEARS OF MASKING

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### It's okay to grieve:

- The childhood support you didn't get
- The friendships lost to masking exhaustion
- The energy spent pretending to be neurotypical
- The burnouts that could have been prevented
- The self you never got to be

### Letter to past me (with compassion):

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# MY AUTISTIC JOY LIST

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**Being autistic isn't all struggle. Celebrate what's GOOD:**

1. \_\_\_\_\_
2. \_\_\_\_\_
3. \_\_\_\_\_
4. \_\_\_\_\_
5. \_\_\_\_\_
6. \_\_\_\_\_
7. \_\_\_\_\_
8. \_\_\_\_\_
9. \_\_\_\_\_
10. \_\_\_\_\_
11. \_\_\_\_\_
12. \_\_\_\_\_
13. \_\_\_\_\_
14. \_\_\_\_\_
15. \_\_\_\_\_

Suggestions: info-dumping about interests, deep focus, pattern recognition, honesty, loyalty, sensory joys, stimming, expertise

WEEKLY ENERGY & MASKING TRACKER - Week 1

| Day | Energy | Masking | Sensory Load | Meltdowns | Special Int. |
|-----|--------|---------|--------------|-----------|--------------|
| Mon |        |         |              |           |              |
| Tue |        |         |              |           |              |
| Wed |        |         |              |           |              |
| Thu |        |         |              |           |              |
| Fri |        |         |              |           |              |
| Sat |        |         |              |           |              |
| Sun |        |         |              |           |              |

Rate 0-10. Notes: \_\_\_\_\_

Patterns I notice: \_\_\_\_\_

Adjustment for next week: \_\_\_\_\_

WEEKLY ENERGY & MASKING TRACKER - Week 2

| Day | Energy | Masking | Sensory Load | Meltdowns | Special Int. |
|-----|--------|---------|--------------|-----------|--------------|
| Mon |        |         |              |           |              |
| Tue |        |         |              |           |              |
| Wed |        |         |              |           |              |
| Thu |        |         |              |           |              |
| Fri |        |         |              |           |              |
| Sat |        |         |              |           |              |
| Sun |        |         |              |           |              |

Rate 0-10. Notes: \_\_\_\_\_

Patterns I notice: \_\_\_\_\_

Adjustment for next week: \_\_\_\_\_

WEEKLY ENERGY & MASKING TRACKER - Week 3

| Day | Energy | Masking | Sensory Load | Meltdowns | Special Int. |
|-----|--------|---------|--------------|-----------|--------------|
| Mon |        |         |              |           |              |
| Tue |        |         |              |           |              |
| Wed |        |         |              |           |              |
| Thu |        |         |              |           |              |
| Fri |        |         |              |           |              |
| Sat |        |         |              |           |              |
| Sun |        |         |              |           |              |

Rate 0-10. Notes: \_\_\_\_\_

Patterns I notice: \_\_\_\_\_

Adjustment for next week: \_\_\_\_\_

WEEKLY ENERGY & MASKING TRACKER - Week 4

| Day | Energy | Masking | Sensory Load | Meltdowns | Special Int. |
|-----|--------|---------|--------------|-----------|--------------|
| Mon |        |         |              |           |              |
| Tue |        |         |              |           |              |
| Wed |        |         |              |           |              |
| Thu |        |         |              |           |              |
| Fri |        |         |              |           |              |
| Sat |        |         |              |           |              |
| Sun |        |         |              |           |              |

Rate 0-10. Notes: \_\_\_\_\_

Patterns I notice: \_\_\_\_\_

Adjustment for next week: \_\_\_\_\_

WEEKLY ENERGY & MASKING TRACKER - Week 5

| Day | Energy | Masking | Sensory Load | Meltdowns | Special Int. |
|-----|--------|---------|--------------|-----------|--------------|
| Mon |        |         |              |           |              |
| Tue |        |         |              |           |              |
| Wed |        |         |              |           |              |
| Thu |        |         |              |           |              |
| Fri |        |         |              |           |              |
| Sat |        |         |              |           |              |
| Sun |        |         |              |           |              |

Rate 0-10. Notes: \_\_\_\_\_

Patterns I notice: \_\_\_\_\_

Adjustment for next week: \_\_\_\_\_

# RESOURCES & COMMUNITY

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## **Online communities:**

- r/AutismInWomen (Reddit)
- r/AutisticAdults (Reddit)
- ASAN (Autistic Self Advocacy Network)
- Embrace Autism (assessment + resources)
- #ActuallyAutistic community (social media)
- Neuroclastic.com (by autistic writers)

## **Books by autistic authors:**

- Unmasking Autism - Devon Price
- Divergent Mind - Jenara Nerenberg
- Is This Autism? - Donna Henderson

**You belong. You always have.**